THE IMPLOSION

IV CORPS HQ (17 NOVEMBER - AFTERNOON)

The large silver-coloured Super Constellation of the VIP Squadron lifted off from Palam Airport in New Delhi and set a course for Tezpur en route to Chabua. Inside the cavernous aircraft, only two seats were occupied. The COAS, General Pran Thapar, and the Director, Military Operations, Brigadier D. K. Palit, were headed east to somehow salvage the situation after the fall of Walong the previous day. In Jammu and Kashmir, after the initial Chinese advances in the Chip Chap and Galwan valleys, the situation seemed to be quiet. In the event of a second Chinese offensive resulting in further advances in Ladakh, Army HQ's assessment was that the Chinese were still a long way from posing any threat to either Kashmir or Punjab as their ability to wage war in this sector was limited to trans-border operations. In all likelihood, even getting to Leh would be beyond Chinese capabilities especially if the Indian troops deployed in Chushul fell back across the Chang-la in time.

In NEFA, even though 11 Brigade had ceased to exist as a cohesive body, a Chinese advance along the Lohit River would be extremely limited and could not be considered a major threat to Assam. As for the Kameng Frontier Division, Thapar and Palit believed that with two brigades holding Se-la, there was a good chance of keeping the Chinese at bay even if the odd Chinese column outflanked the Se-la defences and got to the Bomdila road. Even at this late stage, neither the army chief nor the DMO were aware that the GOC, Major General Anant Pathania, had established his HQ at Dirang Dzong and had deployed only one brigade at Se-la. They were also not aware of the large-scale ingress of Chinese troops across Poshing-la and other routes. As a result, the two officers were not particularly concerned with Se-la, their attention being more on Walong and the situation being faced by the newly raised 2 Infantry Division.